

besides the main 9, like “hr” specifically for discussions in Hungarian, etc.

There are subgroups under each of these main categories, and recursively, more subgroups under those. A newsgroup can be uniquely identified by its address which consists of the names of all the groups it is under—for example `comp.lang.c++` is a newsgroup discussing the C++ programming language which was classified under the languages newsgroup for discussing languages, under the comp groups for discussion on IT topics. It would be hard to make even a rough estimate on the actual number of newsgroups, but it is fairly correct to state that one exists to cater to nearly every human interest.

When compared with Web forums, newsgroups are comparatively “serious” in nature. Unlike forums with their reps and smiles and emoticons and avatars, newsgroups are predominantly all text. But, there are NGs that contain pictures and other content. In fact, `alt.binaries` is an NG that is specially used to post large files like movies etc, almost just like P2P networks. It is probably an indication of the age of the users, but the discussions in newsgroups tend to be serious, and the language formal and mature. Unlike forums where there will be a censor or admin to monitor the content, anything goes in most newsgroups. People are free to post any topic in a newsgroup, but if they expect any meaningful discussion it is best to practice self-censorship. Off topic posts usually get a gentle reminder to repost in the appropriate newsgroup or are simply just ignored, just like all the spam that also floods these servers.

Most NNTP servers charge for granting access to users. Some require you to register. But there are others that are free. Since binaries take up a lot of space and bandwidth, it is almost impossible to come across free NNTP servers offering this category of NG. It is important to realise that the content on most NNTP servers are regularly purged. So the chances of finding older topics are quite slim, but this varies from server to server with some having a shorter retention time than others.

To access NGs a NNTP client or newsreader is needed. NGs can be also be accessed from online sites like `groups.google.com`,